

Insect-eaters and relatives

Many early mammals were not carnivores or herbivores but insectivores, surviving on a diet of insects, worms, snails, and other small animals. They had excellent senses of smell and hearing, but often poor vision. They either made burrows in the ground or lived among the trees. Shy and secretive, many were nocturnal, hunting at night when it was safe to venture out.



Leptictidium

LEP-tick-TID-ee-um



- **When** 40 million years ago (Paleogene)
- **Fossil location** Europe
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 3 ft (1 m)
- **Diet** Insects and other small animals

Leptictidium had enormous hind legs and might have hopped around like a miniature kangaroo, although it could probably scamper on all fours, too. Studies of its skull suggest it had a long, trunklike nose like that of an elephant shrew. It would have used this to sniff out insects and other small animals. Fossilized stomach contents show it fed not only on insects but also on lizards and small mammals.